

Compatibility Counts

Is she really Miss Right?
The new wish list for men ...

- **Communication is king.** She should be able to debate, converse, discuss and challenge his grey cells.
- **Vital attributes no longer mean vital statistics.** Relationship skills, maturity and social style are in now.
- **Look for emotional intelligence:** how she deals with life's stickier moments and her comfort level with his people.
- **Personality matters the most:** a loving, trustworthy girl who will understand him and accept him for who he is.
- **The flavour of the season is the strong, independent woman,** who wouldn't kowtow to his every whim and fancy.

sons to get acquainted with a partner well before the date is set (75 per cent). Mrunalini Deshmukh, lawyer dealing in matrimonial issues in Mumbai, is not surprised. "The rise and social acceptance of divorce are making people think a million times before getting into a wedlock," she points out. "The growing financial independence of women and rise in the age of marriage have made men and women more set in their ways, more opinionated and less likely to adjust." No wonder, old parental calculations are falling by the wayside.

"We have been tracking attitudes in the marriage market

for a long time," says Anupam Mittal, CEO, and founder of the People Group, which owns Shaadi. "For the first time, we notice that men are asserting personal choice and trying to find partners who suit their goals and ambitions." That experience is shared by two other prominent matrimonial sites: BharatMatrimony and Jeevansathi. "This is one area where we have seen the most dramatic changes over the years," says Murugavel Janakiraman, CEO and founder of the Bharat Matrimony group. "Men expect to be posted on the developments and have a big say in deciding the course of action." The new trend could be in reaction to the fact that arranged marriages, more often than not, start with mismatched expectations. In a study ('Arranged Marriages: Parent-Child Relationships, Expectations and Concerns, Roles in the Search', 2005), Sanjeev Bikchandani, the CEO of Jeevansathi, found that if the father of the groom looks for a girl who can become a part of the family like a daughter, the mother looks essentially for an obedient *bahu* and the son tries to balance his preferences with someone who, he thinks, will gel primarily with his mother.

Is the new trend of boys looking for partners themselves a sign of assertion? Actually, its more about practicality. Beauty does not seem to be the most coveted criterion among a significant number. "I am looking for a normal girl," says insurance executive Anshuman Anarkat, 33, of Ahmedabad. "I believe in inner beauty. I have ab-

solutely no fascination for fairness." A Lohana Vaishnav, whose banker father and homemaker mother taught him to be broadminded, seems to be in sync with 42 per cent men in the Shaadi survey who are not hung up on fairness.

"Men are going beyond beauty, as we know it, and are looking at inner beauty," says Janakiraman, whose company added a new Face Search software this year to the BharatMatrimony site. "It

57%

OF MEN SAY COMPATIBILITY IS THE MOST IMPORTANT FACTOR

56%

OF MEN SAY CASTE DOES NOT MATTER, THE PERSON DOES

B.K. KRISHNA, 37, IT engineer, HYDERABAD

A woman's age and looks don't matter much to the man, who believes more in compatibility. That makes Krishna partial to women who are intelligent, independent and honest. He

doesn't favour the joint family system, nor does he want a wife who would go out of her way to please him.

"I haven't come across any woman on the Net who has been forthright in contacting me."



A PRABHAKAR RAO/www.indiatodayimages.com

VIKAS KUMAR, 25, IT engineer, DELHI

His parents encourage him to look for a girl of his choice. But his brush with a girl on the Net—who put a million conditions on him yet left him for a moneyed NRI—has made him bitter. This techie with the Delhi Institute of Technology is looking for a simple girl who would understand his needs and know how to make a happy home.

"Very few girls in the marriage market value a good human being."



REUBEN SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com